

CORRECTING DISTORTED THINKING

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Decrease dysfunctional thinking and increase positive, self-enhancing self-talk.
2. Learn about ways that addictive patterns are related to distorted perceptions and thinking.
3. Identify personal patterns of distorted perceptions that are related to addictive patterns.
4. Learn and use strategies to identify and correct distorted perceptions and to see situations more clearly and accurately.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE DEPRESSION

- Building My Support Network
- Coping with Addiction and Mood Disorders or Bereavement
- Coping with Addiction and Thought Disorders (for depression with psychotic features)
- Coping with Post-Acute Withdrawal (PAW)
- Getting Out of Myself
- How Far Have I Come?
- Interest and Skill Self-Assessment
- Physical and Emotional Self-Care
- Use of Affirmations for Change
- Using Books and Other Media Resources
- Using My Support Network
- What Do Others See Changing?
- What's Happening in My Early Recovery?
- Why Do I Matter and Who Cares?

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Adult-Child-of-an-Alcoholic (ACOA) Traits
- Anger
- Antisocial Behavior
- Anxiety
- Borderline Traits
- Dangerousness
- Dependent Traits

- Narcissistic Traits
- Psychosis
- Social Anxiety/Skills Deficit
- Suicidal Ideation

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Correcting Distorted Thinking” activity is intended primarily for depressed clients, to address Beck’s depressive triad of cognitive distortions and others. It teaches the client about several common forms of cognitive distortion and guides him/her in seeking examples in his/her own life. It follows by offering strategies for overcoming these distortions, and asks the client to test them and to report the results. This exercise is suitable for individual or group use, in session or as homework. Follow-up could include an assignment to use the corrective strategies at least once a day, write about the results, and report outcomes back to the therapist or treatment group.

CORRECTING DISTORTED THINKING

Distorted thinking is a basic problem in depression and in any addiction. We experience denial, in which we can't see or understand things that are obvious to other people. We minimize or exaggerate our problems or achievements. We misinterpret other people's words and actions, and we see ourselves as better or worse than we really are. To solve a problem, the first step must be to see it clearly. Even if we know where we want to go and have a map, we can't get started until we know where we are, and distorted perceptions make that impossible. This exercise will help you see how addictive problems distort our perceptions of ourselves, other people, and our situations, and give you strategies to overcome these distortions.

1. *Denial/minimization.* You don't see or remember your destructive behavior and its negative results, or you don't admit to yourself how serious they are. Here are some examples: You think you may have missed work 3 or 4 times in the last 2 months, when it's really 12 times. You blame arguments with your spouse or partner on him/her, and don't take your share of the responsibility. You don't admit that medical, financial, or relationship problems may be linked to your drinking, drug use, gambling, or other compulsive behavior.

Ways I see this in my life: _____

2. *All-or-nothing thinking.* You see things as completely good or bad, perfect or awful. Events are wonderful or disastrous; you feel like a genius or an idiot; nothing is just okay or average.

Ways I see this in my life: _____

3. *Overgeneralization.* If one thing goes wrong, you feel it's a terrible day; if you make one mistake, you feel you are a mistake; you use the words "always" or "never" often.

Ways I see this in my life: _____

4. *Negative focus.* You exaggerate the negative and overlook the good, seeing the thorns but not the roses. This feeds self-pity, which is an excuse to act out.

Ways I see this in my life: _____

5. *Predicting without facts.* You leap to conclusions about the future, usually negative. You put definitive interpretations on events or actions that don't have clear meanings, such as thinking people are mad at you when they don't act happy, and you don't check to see whether your interpretations are right before you believe them.

Ways I see this in my life: _____

6. *Emotional reasoning.* You assume that your emotions or suspicions reflect the way things really are: "If I feel it, it must be true." One example: "I feel hopeless, so the situation must really be hopeless."

Ways I see this in my life: _____

7. *Should statements.* You guide your actions by what you think you should or shouldn't do, and beat yourself up with guilt and shame when you fail to meet those standards. You may do this to other people, getting angry and judgmental when they don't do what you think they should, even if you never told them what your expectations were.

Ways I see this in my life: _____

8. *Judgment and labeling.* You judge yourself and others instead of judging your actions or their actions. If you lose at something, you call yourself a loser. If others fail at something, you call them failures.

Ways I see this in my life: _____

9. *Taking things personally.* You see other people's actions as being aimed at you, and you feel responsible for things you don't control.

Ways I see this in my life: _____

10. Here's a strategy to correct distorted thinking: Check it out with someone you trust. When you're upset about a situation, talk with your sponsor or someone else you trust who isn't emotionally involved. Tell them what happened. Tell only what you actually saw and heard, not what you believe others were thinking or feeling. Ask your sponsor or friend what he/she thinks, and share your thoughts and feelings. Ask him/her whether it seems you're making one of the mistakes above. Try this and describe what happens.

11. Here's another strategy. When you feel upset, take a piece of paper and draw five columns. In the first column, describe the upsetting situation or event. Use the next column to list your emotions (e.g., anger, fear, despair, worry, confusion, embarrassment, shame). Rate the strength of each emotion on a 10-point scale, with 10 being the most intense. In column three, write down

what you think about the situation. Now review the distortions described earlier. In the fourth column, write a nondistorted, reasonable replacement thought that is probably true for each distorted thought in column two. Think about this thought briefly. Then, in the last column, list your emotions after filling out column four, just as you did in column two. Have your emotions changed? How will you handle the situation differently than you would have based on the emotions and thoughts with which you started?

Be sure to bring this handout back to your next session with your therapist, and be prepared to talk about your thoughts and feelings about the exercise.